

NFL will allow coaches to designate staff member to initiate replay challenges



For the first time in the NFL, team staffers other than a head coach can throw a red challenge flag on the field. Jamie Squire / Getty Images



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Beginning this season, head coaches will no longer be the only ones allowed to initiate replay challenges, according to a change in the NFL rulebook.

Rule 15 (instant replay), Section 1 (initiating a replay review), Article 1 (coach challenges) now [reads](#), “The Head Coach or head coach’s pregame challenge designee can initiate a challenge by throwing a red flag onto the field of play before

the next legal snap or kick.” Previously, only the head coach could carry the red challenge flag and throw it on the field to stop the game for a challenge.

The rule change was not included among the changes the NFL announced earlier this offseason, but the league can make some tweaks to rules that don’t require a vote from the owners.



It’s important to note that the rule is an either/or situation; it does not *add* to the total number of individuals allowed to initiate a challenge per team. That number remains one, according to a league official who spoke on condition of anonymity because they weren’t authorized to comment on the matter. That means if the head

coach designates a member of his sideline staff to initiate challenges, the head coach will not have the ability to throw the flag on the field. As has been the case, the coaching staff — on the sidelines and in the press box — can communicate through headsets, so the head coach could still be involved in the decision-making process and offer the final verdict, even if another individual throws the flag.

Designating a sideline staff member for this is optional, so it remains to be seen how many head coaches will choose to delegate the responsibility rather than retain it for themselves.

Saad Yousuf is a staff writer covering the NFL. He previously covered the Dallas Cowboys and the Dallas Stars at The Athletic. Saad also works at 96.7/1310 The Ticket in Dallas after five years at ESPN Dallas radio. Prior to The Athletic, Saad covered the Cowboys, Mavericks and a variety of other sports at The Dallas Morning News.

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